

Praise of the Glorious Vajrabhairava

Śrīvajrabhairavastava · Toh 471 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་རྡོ་རྗེ་འཇགས་བརྩེ་ལ་ཕགྱ་འཆལ་ལ།

Toh 471 in the Kangyur is a tantric text known in Tibetan as Dpal Dorje Jikjé, and in Sanskrit as Śrī Vajrabhairava, belonging to the cycle of teachings associated with the wrathful deity Vajrabhairava, the great destroyer of death. The text is a ritual or narrative scripture in which Vajrabhairava, arising from the vajra body, speech, and mind of the Buddha, storms the southern realm of Yama, the Lord of Death, shattering iron fortresses and compelling the terrified demonic and infernal forces to submit and pledge their obedience. It belongs to the class of tantric literature within the Kangyur and is connected to the Vajrabhairava cycle, one of the most important Highest Yoga Tantra traditions preserved especially in the Geluk school of Tibetan Buddhism. The translation into Tibetan was made by Nyima Gyaltsen, and the text's vivid, hymnic opening sets the scene of Vajrabhairava's cosmic victory over the forces of death and obstruction.

Translated, edited, and finalized by Nyima Gyaltsen.

Homage to the glorious Vajrabhairava!

Now what is to be properly explained:

The great Vajrabhairava, arisen from the vajras of body, speech, and mind of the Blessed One himself, crossed beyond the southern ocean. He then came to the city of Yama (the Lord of Death), to the place of Gālava. With his sixteen terrible feet he smashed the sixteen iron citadels with their sixteen gateless entrances. With the sign of one-pointed wisdom-gnosis he smashed the great central iron fortress.

At that moment the great māra fell into a swoon, and crying out "Ha ha! Hi hi!" he and the others — the Dharma King (Yama) and the rest — spoke under duress, saying:

"O great hero, wherever you are, whatever the hero requires, we shall perform. Please accept what we offer: the very cores of our lives. Receive them, O hero."

The life-essences offered by the eight classes of gods and rākṣasas: Yama offered "yā," the mother-demons offered "mā," the rākṣasas offered "rā," the yakṣas (yakṣa) offered "kṣe," humans offered "ṇi," the local lords of the earth offered "sā," the btsan spirits offered "tsa," the māras offered "da." All of these

gathered together into one, and they pledged themselves as servants.

On account of that great binding oath, having thoroughly entered into the intention of the wisdom deity and having fully absorbed the retreat practice, having entered into the retreat of the deity, they will not transgress their former sacred bond. It is impossible that the aim should not be accomplished.

"Ya ma rā dza sa do me ya, ya me do ru ṇa yo da ya, ya da yo ni ra ya kṣe ya, yakṣe yaccha nī rā ma ya."

When those words were spoken, the great Vajrabhairava blessed the Dharma King and all the other messengers of Yama as liberation-givers. He then gave command to the mothers, sisters, and daughters, together with their retinues: "At the end of the five-hundred-year period, when my teaching arises in the world, you shall duly perform your commanded activities for those yogins and vidyādharas (holders of awareness-mantras)." Having sworn this oath —

Translator's Notes

- The syllables "yā," "mā," "rā," "kṣe," "ṇi," "sā," "tsa," "da" are presented in the Tibetan as individual phonetic contributions (bīja-syllables) made by each class of beings toward the formation of a mantra or oath. The interpretation of which syllable belongs to which class follows the sequence given in the text itself, though the correspondences are tightly compressed and the reading of some syllables (particularly "ṇi" for humans and "kṣe" for yakṣas) depends on the phonetic glosses embedded in the Tibetan lines.

The four lines of mantra-syllables ("ya ma rā dza sa do me ya" etc.) are transliterated directly from the Tibetan phonetic rendering and are not translated, as they constitute a ritual dhāraṇī formula.

The phrase "liberation-givers" (འགྲོ་བུ་འཕེལ་བའི་མཁན་པོ་མང་པོ་།) renders a compound meaning something like "ging-spirits of liberation" — ging being a class of wrathful attendant spirits associated with Vajrabhairava's retinue who are charged with liberating beings.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of

stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.